



GHANA, YOUR BELOVED COUNTRY, IS FREE FOREVER

NKRUMAH WINS GHANAIAN INDEPENDENCE (1957)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Postcolonial Africa

BEFORE

1946 The formation of the international Pan-African Federation promotes African independence.

1952–1960 The Mau Mau uprising in Kenya against the British marks a turning point in the struggle for independence.

1956 A humiliating defeat for France and Britain in Suez signals a further decline of the old European powers.

AFTER

1957–1975 Most African nations achieve independence from French, British, Portuguese, and Belgian rule.

1963 The Organization of African Unity is founded.

1994 South Africans are the last people on the continent to achieve majority rule.

In February 1948, at a time when the Gold Coast, a British colony in West Africa, had been demanding independence for several years, a group of unarmed African ex-servicemen marched to the British governor with a petition of grievances. Ordered to stop, they refused, and the police opened fire.



Kwame Nkrumah, Kojo Botsio, Krobo Edusei, and other Ghanaian politicians celebrate the independence of their country, which was achieved peacefully and democratically.

In response to this, in 1949, nationalist Kwame Nkrumah formed the Convention People's Party (CPP), an organization fighting for self-governance. Nkrumah initiated a campaign of positive action inspired by Gandhi's philosophy of nonviolent noncooperation in India against the British. The strikes and protests they encouraged remained peaceful but paralyzed the country, and Britain agreed to elections in early 1951. The CPP won 35 out of 38 seats, and the Gold Coast moved rapidly toward independence, which was proclaimed on March 6, 1957, with Nkrumah becoming prime minister of the nation of Ghana. It was a moment of huge hope for a new kind of Africa.

The European powers that ruled Africa had been impoverished by World War II, and attitudes to colonialism were changing. Nations that had fought against fascism found it hard to justify imperialism.

A domino effect

Events in Ghana had a significant impact in West Africa. In 1958, Guinea voted to secede from France. Determined not to be left behind, Nigeria celebrated independence from Britain on October 1, 1960. By 1964, independence had also been granted